

JAMS AND JELLIES



Adults

Q

What is the recommended headspace to leave when filling jars with hot jam or jelly before sealing?

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ANSWER

1/4 inch headspace

FUN FACT

Proper headspace ensures a good vacuum seal for safe storage.

Source: SP 50-632 Making berry syrups at home

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Q

Why must you follow the manufacturer's instructions exactly when making freezer jams with commercial pectin?

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ANSWER

Different pectins require specific preparation methods and cannot be substituted.

FUN FACT

Using the wrong pectin or recipe can result in runny or grainy freezer jam.

Source: SP 50-632 Making berry syrups at home

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At what temperature above the boiling point of water should you cook jam or jelly mixtures to reach the gelling point?

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ANSWER

8 degrees F above the boiling point

FUN FACT

Cooking to the right temperature ensures the jam will set properly.

Source: EM 9446 Playing it safe when preserving elderberries

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Q

What is the minimum processing time in boiling water canner for jams and jellies at elevations below 1,000 feet?

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ANSWER

5 minutes

FUN FACT

Processing ensures safe preservation and shelf stability.

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What effect does reducing sugar have on jams made with traditional commercial pectin recipes?

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ANSWER

The product will fail to gel properly and be syrupy

FUN FACT

Sugar is crucial for gel formation with traditional pectin blends.

Source: SP 50-632 Making berry syrups at home

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What is the proper method for sterilizing jars used for hot-pack jams and jellies?

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ANSWER

**Boil jars for 10 minutes if
under 1,000 feet elevation**

FUN FACT

*Sterilized jars reduce the risk of
spoilage during storage.*

Source: EM 9446 Playing it safe when preserving
elderberries

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For freezer jams, why is it important to use the exact amount of fruit and juice specified in the recipe?

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ANSWER

To ensure proper gel formation and prevent spoilage

FUN FACT

Overloading with fruit can cause runny jams or fermentation.

Source: SP 50-632 Making berry syrups at home



Q

How long can freezer jams typically be kept in the freezer for best quality?

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ANSWER

Up to one year

FUN FACT

Freezer jams keep their fresh fruit flavor longer than cooked jams.

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What is the role of acid in jam and jelly making?

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ANSWER

It aids gel formation and adds flavor

FUN FACT

Lemon juice is commonly added to low-acid fruits for better gel.

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What adjustment is commonly made when canning jams at elevations above 6,000 feet?



ANSWER

Increase processing time to 15 minutes

FUN FACT

Higher elevations require longer processing to ensure safety.

Source: SP 50-632 Making berry syrups at home



Q

Why should you not double freezer jam recipes?

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ANSWER

It's difficult to dissolve sugar and may result in runny jam

FUN FACT

Small batches help ensure sugar dissolves evenly and gel sets well.

Source: SP 50-632 Making berry syrups at home

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What is a sign that jam or jelly has reached the 'gel point' when cooking on the stove?



ANSWER

Mixture sheets from a spoon

FUN FACT

Testing with a spoon helps you know when to stop cooking.

Source: EM 9446 Playing it safe when preserving elderberries



Q

What is the recommended storage condition for freezer jams once opened?

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ANSWER

Store in the refrigerator

FUN FACT

Freezer jams are not cooked and can spoil quickly at room temperature after opening.

Source: SP 50-632 Making berry syrups at home



Q

Which type of commercial pectin is made from citrus fruits?



ANSWER

Powdered pectin

FUN FACT

Powdered pectin requires different use instructions than liquid pectin.

Source: SP 50-632 Making berry syrups at home

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When making jams with low or no sugar pectin, what is a common natural sweetener used in the recipe?



ANSWER

Concentrated apple juice

FUN FACT

Low sugar pectin recipes often call for concentrated apple juice for flavor and gel.

Source: SP 50-632 Making berry syrups at home

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What is the recommended process time for a hot-pack jam jar at 3,000 feet elevation?

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ANSWER

10 minutes

FUN FACT

Processing times increase with elevation for safety.

Source: SP 50-632 Making berry syrups at home

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Why is sugar important besides gel formation in jam making?

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ANSWER

It acts as a preservative by preventing microbial growth

FUN FACT

Sugar helps the jam stay safe and tasty during storage.

Source: SP 50-632 Making berry syrups at home



Q

How long should sugar and mashed fruit mixture stand when making uncooked freezer jam before adding pectin?

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ANSWER

10 minutes

FUN FACT

This soaking time helps dissolve the sugar into the fruit juice.

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What can cause a jam or jelly to weep or release liquid after setting?



ANSWER

Too much acid in the recipe

FUN FACT

Balancing acid is essential to maintaining a stable gel.

Source: SP 50-632 Making berry syrups at home

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If you want seedless jam, what is the recommended method before adding sugar and cooking?



ANSWER

Press crushed berries through a sieve or food mill

FUN FACT

Straining removes seeds for a smoother jam texture.

Source: SP 50-632 Making berry syrups at home